

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

It says a lot about how banal Bollywood has become now that an 84-year-old can give it its most tabloid-ready tittle-tattle. I wanted to commit suicide because of Suraiya! Zeenat Aman broke my heart! I got Sanju Baba his bride! Bollywood autobiographies are sanitised accounts which either deny the star's love life, like the recent palimpsest by Vyjayanthimala, or are ghost-written gush-fests that keep the third person aura alive. Readers are rarely allowed a peek into the private hedonism whose delicious tales adorn magazine covers and tabloid front pages. The feeling of being let down is especially acute when it comes to the shining stars of the 1950s, the golden age of Indian cinema. The tempestuous Raj Kapoor-Nargis love affair, Dilip Kumar swearing undying love for Madhubala or Guru Dutt's doomed love for Waheeda Rehman, this is the stuff that legends are made of, their stories acquiring currency by being repeated across bucolic barbershops and bored babu offices. In this age of stars kissing but not telling, having relationships but not ratting on them, and putting a holier-than-thou spin on even the most salacious scandal, thank God for one hand-kissing, posh-speaking, beret-doffing romantic, at ease with kings and beauty queens, with corporate czars and saucy 16-year-olds, a man who can still go weak in the knees when he sees a beautiful girl—and be happy to admit to it. We may no longer have to like Dev Anand's movies, but we can celebrate his life so far, as he recounts his exploits on the shooting floor and in the bedroom in fabulously florid prose in *Romancing With Life, An Autobiography* (Viking, Rs 695).



ROMANCING WITH LIFE, AN AUTOBIOGRAPHY
by DEV ANAND
Viking
Price: Rs 695;
Pages: 426

ONE LIFE, MANY LADIES

The evergreen star's greatest romance is with himself, but his beloved beauty queens and saucy 16-year-olds come a close second in an autobiography that spends as much time in bedrooms as it does on studio floors

There are not too many tinsel-edged profundities, instead there is an unmistakable enthusiasm for life which sets the adrenaline pumping. His account of how he and Guru Dutt were sleeping with the same woman, sadly left unnamed; his almost-affair with a Czech interpreter that enraged his wife, actor Kalpana Kartik (a.k.a. Mona Singha); an on-off relationship with an Irish student at Cambridge while she was working as a cleaner in his Swiss hotel; his sharing a room with Marlon Brando's assistant in France; and his unusual talent for casting nubile nymphets, who almost always seem to assault him in places as varied as New York and London, make compelling reading. Unrepentant voyeurs would like all the details but Anand doesn't quite oblige us—there are several affairs he omits, among them a long-standing one with the niece of a famous

star, another with an Air-India stewardess, and yet another with a '60s beauty queen. Still the juicy morsels are fairly substantial. And not only always about sex, though there's an awful lot of it in the book—and some of it awfully graphic.

There's a near-death car accident with Geeta Bali seated next to him in his Chevrolet convertible, a meeting with Jawaharlal Nehru where he, Dilip Kumar and Raj Kapoor asked about Edwina Mountbatten, a run-in with the government during the Emergency, and several meetings with Indira Gandhi, whom he declares behaved like a *gunji gudiya* with him. There is a fallout with his elder brother Chetan whom he idolised for his English gentleman ways; his great working relationship with younger brother Goldie (they did memorable work together, such as *Johnny Mera Naam* and *Guide*), and several indiscreet hints about his wife's

